



Bridging the James River

Between June 14 and June 17, 1864, Union engineers laid a pontoon bridge, employing 101 pontoons, to span a nearly half-mile (800-m) wide stretch of the James River.

Feats of transportation

While Grant was “all-observant, silent, inscrutable,” as one subordinate put it, the Eighteenth Corps under General William F. Smith marched northeast to board troop transports waiting on the York River. Most of the infantry marched south to the north shore of the James River, and were ferried to the opposite bank. The rest—one corps and one division, plus all the artillery—crossed the river on a pontoon bridge that had been erected in only seven hours. The troops were followed by 5,000 wagons, 56,000 horses and mules, and 2,800 head of cattle. For three days an unbroken cavalcade plodded over the bridge.

Initial attacks

Smith’s Eighteenth Corps, which included a United States Colored Troops (USCT) division, was the first to arrive, disembarking at City Point on June 15 and marching 10 miles (16km) toward Petersburg.